

Matt Thomson

PhD Candidate & International Development Consultant

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PROFESSIONAL PROFILE

University of Bristol PhD candidate and international development specialist with an operational track record leading multi-country programmes, EU co-financed initiatives, and grassroots partnerships across East and West Africa. Specialises in the politics of localisation and assistive technology networks, connecting academic evidence with field operations. Experienced in securing institutional funding, designing qualitative field research, and managing the transition of regional NGO networks from aid dependency toward sustainable, self-directed models.

CORE EXPERTISE

Qualitative Research & Analysis. Field-based data collection, systems auditing, and translating development theory into functional field methodologies and toolkits.

Partnership Architecture. Building networks between donors, academic institutions, disabled people's organisations, and local civil society.

Programme & Grant Management. Co-managing multi-year, EU co-financed initiatives, statutory funding blocks, and compliance frameworks across Sub-Saharan Africa.

Institutional Growth. Authoring high-value bids and designing strategies that scale NGO operations.

EDUCATION

PhD in Politics, University of Bristol	In progress, Jan 2024 – present
Research focus: the politics of localisation in Sub-Saharan Africa, tracking how structural power, expertise, and capital move through the international development ecosystem.	
MSc Development and Security, University of Bristol	Distinction, 2019 – 2020
Thesis: how small-scale NGOs maximise structural impact through cross-sector collaboration and systemic partnership design in Uganda.	
BA International Relations & History, Oxford Brookes University	2:1, 2016 – 2019

PROFESSIONAL EXPERIENCE

STAND

Bristol, UK & Sub-Saharan Africa

Community Partnerships & Research Manager

Mar 2022 – present

Formerly Legs4Africa. Promoted from Fundraising Manager, Oct 2023.

- Leads STAND's participation in a large EU Horizon-funded research consortium with multiple universities and the Exceed Research Network, studying assistive technology supply chains, rehabilitation, policy, and data systems.
- Co-manages a multi-year, EU co-financed development programme in The Gambia: budget management, partner compliance, strategic impact reporting.
- Leads multi-country portfolios across Uganda, Kenya, and Tanzania, managing the transition of grassroots networks toward localised, sustainable operating models.
- Built and manages an advisory network of UK and international academics integrating public health research into field clinics.
- Supervises university placement students in field research methods, ethics, and qualitative health systems analysis.
- Secured institutional grants and led fundraising strategy that expanded the organisation's annual income and operational scale.
- Conducts regular field visits across Sub-Saharan Africa, predominantly Uganda and The Gambia, for systems audits, focus groups, and key informant interviews.

University of Bristol, School of Sociology, Politics and International Studies

Bristol, UK

Postgraduate Researcher & Seminar Tutor, Politics

Jan 2024 – present

- Doctoral research on the politics of localisation in Sub-Saharan Africa, examining power dynamics and funding flows in development ecosystems.
- Delivers weekly undergraduate seminars across Political Science, International Relations, and Global Public Policy, including facilitation, assessment, and mentorship.
- Guest lecturer on the University of Southampton's MSc in Amputation & Prosthetic Rehabilitation, connecting international policy frameworks with clinical field realities.

SWIDN

Member-Trustee

Aug 2026 – present

- Sits on the board as the member-trustee, the seat reserved for someone working inside an NGO in the network.
- Brings academic research into the network's strategy and programming.
- Develops academic partnerships supporting development work across the South West.

Exceed Research Network

Global academic consortium

Researcher & Contributor

2024 – present

- Partners with an international consortium of universities, health ministries, and NGOs building the evidence base for Prosthetics & Orthotics services in low-resource settings.
- Supports cross-institutional data analysis linking academic research to field-level healthcare delivery.

Professional affiliation: ISPO Associate.

EARLIER EXPERIENCE

International Institute of Debate (iiDebate)

Tunis, Tunisia

External Relations & Fundraising Coordinator

Sep 2021 – Mar 2022

- Developed international networking and fundraising pipelines to secure institutional donors and scale delivery into new markets.
- Managed deliverables across simultaneous initiatives, including an internal monitoring and evaluation consultancy unit.
- Editor-in-Chief for Youth Polyphony; directed institutional events and journalism academy programmes.

The Next Century Foundation

Penzance, UK & remote, Middle East

Research Officer

May 2021 – Sep 2021

- Delivered an Oral Intervention to the United Nations Human Rights Council on regional humanitarian and policy issues.
- Co-authored non-papers on the Middle East Peace Process; facilitated conferences with state officials, civil society leaders, and journalists.

Pepal

Bristol, UK & Uganda

International Development Intern

Sep 2019 – Mar 2020

- Developed crisis management plans for public utility operations facing security developments within a DFID-funded programme in Uganda.
- Evaluated management, evaluation, and field security infrastructure across multi-stakeholder interventions.

KEY SKILLS

Research & Evaluation. Qualitative and quantitative fieldwork, M&E, systems auditing, ethical frameworks, theory of change validation, NVivo.

Communication & Advisory. Teaching, workshop facilitation, statutory bid writing, stakeholder management, public speaking, safeguarding programmes.

Operations & Compliance. Institutional contract management, budgeting, compliance, logistics, Sub-Saharan Africa partnerships (Uganda, The Gambia, Kenya, Tanzania), ethics approvals.

Languages. English (native), Spanish (B1).